

8. Even More Integral Applications

8.5. Probability

8.5 Learning Objectives

- Understand how we describe probability of events using integrals
- Identify whether a function can be a probability density function
- Find probability of events occurring using a PDF
- Find the mean value of a PDF

Definition 8.5.1 Probability

The **probability** of an event is how likely the event is to occur, and is restricted to values between $[0, 1]$.

Example 8.5.1

If you flip a coin, the probability it lands on either side is 0.5 (which we normally translate to 50%).

Definition 8.5.2 Discrete Random Variable

X is a **discrete random variable** if it is a number that represents an outcome that can only be certain distinct values.

Example 8.5.2

The result of rolling a six sided die, or the number of times you need to flip a coin before getting “heads” are two examples of discrete random variables. The first has a finite set of outcomes: $\{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$, the second has a countable set of outcomes: $\{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, \dots\}$ (depending on how unlucky you are).

8.5.1. Continuous Random Variables

We’ll spend our time in probability land here:

Definition 8.5.3 Continuous Random Variable

X is a **continuous random variable** if it is a number that represents an outcome that can take any real value on some interval.

Example 8.5.3

- The height of a randomly selected person on Earth is a continuous random variable, the person *could* be any height from 0 feet to 10 feet tall, so the random variable has a set of outcomes $[0, 10]$. (In a fancy probability class you'd call this interval the support of the random variable, but you don't need to know that for now)
- The number of inches a die rolls after dropping it is a continuous random variable, the die *could* roll anywhere from 0 inches to 12 inches (because your dice rolling tray is only 12 inches long and has negligible width ;). This random variable has a set of outcomes in $[0, 12]$.
- The number of hours before the Colorado Rockies win a Baseball game is a continuous random variable (so long as we are being VERY exact about our timing (t can be any positive real number) and taking care to think about when the game is, etc). The Rockies *could* win their next game (we'll assume it ends in 2 hours) or they may never win again, so this random variable can have an outcome in $[120, \infty)$.

Property 8.5.1 Probability Density Function

Every continuous random variable, X has a **probability density function**, $f(x)$, such that

- The probability that X is between a and b is given by

$$P(a \leq X \leq b) = \int_a^b f(x) dx.$$

- The probability density function is always non-negative,

$$f(x) \geq 0$$

- The “total probability” is 1, that is

$$\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(x) dx = 1$$

Note

For a continuous random variable X , the probability that $X = c$ for any real c in the set of possible outcomes of X is 0. This is because no matter the probability density function $f(x)$, $\int_c^c f(x) dx = 0$.

Fun Fact

Although you do not have the tools to integrate e^{-x^2} , a scaled version of this is a probability density function that represents the normal distribution! It has domain $(-\infty, \infty)$ Specifically,

$$f(x) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}\sigma^2} \exp\left(-\frac{(x - \mu)^2}{2\sigma^2}\right)$$

for some constants μ, σ . So, we know that

$$\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi\sigma^2}} \exp\left(-\frac{(x-\mu)^2}{2\sigma^2}\right) dx = 1.$$

Example 8.5.4

Let

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} \frac{1}{6}x(10-x) & 0 \leq x \leq 10 \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Could $f(x)$ be a PDF for some continuous random variable?

Solution

We need to check 2 things. Is $f(x) \geq 0$, and is $\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(x) dx = 1$?

First, for $0 \leq x \leq 10$, we have $\frac{1}{6}x \geq 0$ and $10 - x \geq 0$ and the product of 2 non-negative numbers is non-negative. Outside this interval $f(x) = 0 \geq 0$ so yes, $f(x) \geq 0$ everywhere.

Second, we check the integral

$$\begin{aligned} \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(x) dx &= \int_{-\infty}^0 0 dx + \int_0^{10} \frac{1}{6}x(10-x) dx + \int_{10}^{\infty} 0 dx \\ &= 0 + \int_0^{10} \frac{1}{6}x(10-x) dx + 0 \end{aligned}$$

8.5 Section Summary: